

Overview

A descriptive typology of clause-internal Condition C judgments:

Violations	Reject	Non-violations	
		Accept	Reject
	Accept	English Kanien’kéha (Baker 1996)	Warlpiri (Legate 2002) Chuj (Royer 2025)

- Some languages fit into several cells (e.g., Malayalam, Mohanan 1983; Hungarian, Marác̣z and Muysken 1989; Choe 1989; Passamaquoddy, Bruening 2001).

If Condition C is universal (Reuland 2011), a typology is unexpected!

- Concerted effort to derive this surface behavior from language-internal quirks.
 - Properties resulting in Condition C variation: object shift (Legate 2002; Royer 2025), anticataphora (Mohanan 1983; Royer 2025), anaphoric islands (Legate 2002), accidental coreference (Bruening 2001; Reinhart 1983).
- Baker (1996) suggests another way to account for unexpected Condition C behavior in Kanien’kéha (Mohawk): sentence level adjunction of all overt nominals.

Proposal (in a nutshell): Structural ambiguity allows for apparent Condition C violations in Kanien’kéha.
→ Maintains Condition C’s universality, without positing recourse to other macroparameters.

Condition C is relevant in Kanien’kéha

- Matrix *pros* may corefer with R-expressions in adjuncts but not those in complement clauses (Baker 1996).

(1) *Wa’ewennahnó:ton ohén:ton ne Katerí: aonsaionhtén:ti.*
pro_i wa’-ie-wennahnoton ohenton ne Kateri_i aonsa-ion-ahntenti
FACT-FIA-read[PUNC] before NE Kateri OPT.REP-FIA-go[PUNC]
‘She_i read it before Catherine_i left.’

(2) *Wa’è:ron tsi Sosén: teiekahrí:ios.*
*pro*_{i/j} wa’-ie-ihron tsi Sosen_i te-ie-kahr-iio-s*
FACT-FIA-say.PUNC C Sosen DUP-FIA-eye-good-HAB
‘She*_{i/j} said that Susan_i has nice eyes.’

This asymmetry follows from standard definitions of binding (e.g., Chomsky 1981; Reinhart 1976, 1983).

⇒ Condition C relevant for appearance of R-expressions in Kanien’kéha.

!! It appears that *pro* subjects can be coreferential with R-expression possessors of objects...

(3) *RBChne thá:iens (ne) Wishe raohwista’.*
RBC-hne t-ha-ien-s ne Wishe rao-hwist-a’
RBC-LOC CIS-MSGA-lay-HAB NE Michael MSGP-money-NSF
‘Michael_i keeps his_i money at RBC.’ (Baker: ‘He_i keeps Michael_i’s money at RBC.’)

Baker’s (1996) analysis

- Objects seem able to appear outside of c-command domain of subject *pro*.
⇒ Overt nominals are adjoined to the sentential level (licensed by a *pro* in argument position).

High adjunction at the sentential level allows overt nominals to escape c-command by *pros* in argument position = no Condition C effects.

⇒ **Condition C can be saved, but only if languages vary at a fundamental level.**

This relies on R-expression in examples like (3) being object-internal...

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Structural ambiguity: an analysis

Pace Baker, **structural ambiguity** is behind the apparent Condition C violations. Arises from a combination of *flexible word order* and *robust pro-drop*.

- Results in strings with multiple parses. ⇒ Creates the illusion of Condition C violations.

Actual parse of the Condition C "violation" in (3):

(4) *RBChne thá:iens [(ne) Wishe_i]_{SUBJ} [*pro_i* *raohwista*]_{OBJ}*

- Speakers *always* accept coreferential readings for ambiguous strings: they are always reparsable in a non-violating way.

Some repercussions:

- (i) Condition C remains universal. Violations can be chalked up to surface properties.
- (ii) Another crosslinguistic "tool" languages can use to "bleed" Condition C.
- (iii) Condition C behavior in Kanien’kéha is *not* evidence for deviation from standard argument structure approaches (contra Baker 1996).
- (iv) Condition C cannot always be reliably tested with simple sentences (Legate 2002; Royer 2025).

New evidence from conjoined possessed objects

Prediction: In cases where structural ambiguity does **not** arise vis-à-vis an R-expression, Condition C effects should be found as usual. ⇒ Enter conjoined possessed objects!

- Both orderings of possessors and possessa are well-formed.

(5) *Wahiiientéhrha’ne’ ne {Warisó:se akóhskare. / akóhskare Warisó:se.}*
wa’-hi-ientehrha’n-e’ ne Warisose ako-hskar-e’ ako-hskar-e’ Warisose
FACT-1SG>MSG-meet-PUNC NE Josephine FIP-partner-NSF FIP-partner-NSF Josephine
‘I met Josephine’s boyfriend.’

Asymmetry of allowed coreference between subject and (apparent) R-expression possessor of an object conjunct **based on ordering** of possessor and possessum.

- No** coreference when the R-expression occurs *after the first conjunct or before the second*.

(6) a. *Wahó:ti ne raonhotónkwa Kó:r tánon’ raò:sere.*
*pro*_{i/j} wa-ho-ati ne rao-nhotonkwa Kor_i tanon’ pro_i rao-’sere*
FACT-MSGP-lose[PUNC] NE MSGP-key Paul and MSGP-car
‘He*_{i/j} lost Paul’s keys and his_i car.’
b. *Wahó:ti ne raonhotónkwa tánon’ Kó:r raò:sere.*
*pro*_{i/j} wa-ho-ati ne pro*_{i/j} rao-nhotonkwa tanon’ Kor_i rao-’sere*
FACT-MSGP-lose[PUNC] NE MSGP-key and Paul MSGP-car
‘He*_{i/j} lost his*_{i/j} keys and Paul’s car.’ (SUBJ ≠ OBJ poss’r)

- Coreference** when the R-expression occurs *before the first conjunct or after the second*.

(7) a. *Wahó:ti ne Kó:r raonhotónkwa tánon’ raò:sere.*
pro_i wa-ho-ati ne Kor_i rao-nhotonkwa tanon’ pro_i rao-’sere
FACT-MSGP-lose[PUNC] NE Paul MSGP-key and MSGP-car
‘Paul_i lost his_i keys and his_i car.’
b. *Wahó:ti ne raonhotónkwa tánon’ raò:sere Kó:r.*
pro_i wa-ho-ati ne pro_i rao-nhotonkwa tanon’ rao-’sere Kor_i
FACT-MSGP-lose[PUNC] NE MSGP-key and MSGP-car Paul
‘Paul_i lost his_i keys and his_i car.’ (SUBJ = OBJ poss’r)

Here’s the schema (using choice brackets):

(8) a. V NP_{OBJ} {R-exp} *tánon’* {R-exp} NP_{OBJ} → ✗ Subject and possessor of object coreference
b. V {R-exp} NP_{OBJ} *tánon’* NP_{OBJ} {R-exp} → ✓ Subject and possessor of object coreference

- Baker has **no clear account for the obligatory disjoint reference in (6)**.
- Overt objects should always be high-adjoined. → Possessor R-expressions should always escape the c-command domain of subject *pro* despite ordering.

Analysis

- Examples in (6) **are not** structurally ambiguous w.r.t. the location of the R-expression.
- Conjuncts must be parsed together (CSC holds; Boles 2024), "trapping" the R-expression as a possessor inside the object.
 - Only licit parse forces *pro* subject → **Condition C violation! No coreference allowed.**

(9) V [*pro*_{i/j}*]_{SUBJ} [NP {R-exp_i} *tánon’* {R-exp_i} NP]_{OBJ}

- Examples in (7) **are** structurally ambiguous w.r.t. the location of the R-expression.
- Possible to parse the R-expression as a possessor internal to the object, forcing a disjoint reading...

(10) V [*pro*_{i/j}*]_{SUBJ} [{R-exp_i} NP *tánon’* NP {R-exp_i}]_{OBJ}

- A parse exists where the R-expression is separate from the conjoined objects. R-expression subject remains unbound: **No Condition C violation! Coreference allowed.**

(11) V [{R-exp_i}_{SUBJ}] [*pro_i* NP *tánon’* *pro_i* NP]_{OBJ} [{R-exp_i}_{SUBJ}]

- The existence of a non-violating parse voids Condition C effects when speakers are asked for coreference judgments. Any structurally ambiguous sentences are able to receive a coreference reading (e.g., 3).
Condition C tests only reliable with more complex sentences in some languages.

If the location of the R-expression is unambiguous, Condition C effects arise as expected.
Condition C remains universal. Another path to "variant" Condition C behavior.

The data only follow if the subject asymmetrically c-commands the object. ⇒ **No argument structure gymnastics required for Kanien’kéha.**

Baker’s tests are not sufficient

Baker (1996) goes through tests against my proposed parse, but these are **not sufficient**.

- **Test 1: Polar questions.** Argues the polar question particle *ken* is a second position clitic following a full constituent, so the R-expression must be inside of the object DP.
Problem: Third position *ken* is acceptable when the first DP is a topic (Flaim 2025).
⇒ Unclear what to make of (12); no contexts or prosodic data in Baker 1996.

(12) *Onwá:ri akóhskare’ ken wa’thonwanoronhkwánion’?*
Onwari_i ako-hskar-e’ ken pro_i wa’t-honwa-noronhkw-a-nion-’
Onwari FIP-partner-NSF Q FACT.DUP-FI>MSG-kiss-PUNC
‘Did she_i kiss Mary_i’s boyfriend?’ (Baker’s translation) (Baker 1996:46, K.)

(13) *Katya só:ra ken én:ieke’?*
Katya sora ken en-ie-k-e’
Katya duck Q FUT-FIA-eat-PUNC
‘As for Katya, will she eat the duck?’ (Flaim 2025)

- **Test 2: CNPs.** Suggests subject *pros* may corefer with R-expressions in CNP objects.
Problem: Not replicable.

(14) *Kaná:takon wa’(e)tshiseni:ken’ í:se’ tánon’ Sá:k raòhskare’.*
ka-nat-a-kon pro wa’-(e)tshiseni-ken-’ ise’ tanon’ Sak rao-hskar-e’
NA-town-JR-in.LOC FACT-MSG>2DU-see-PUNC 2PRO and Sak MSGP-partner-NSF
‘He_i saw you and Sá:k_i’s girlfriend in town.’ (Baker’s speakers’ judgments)
‘He*_{i/j} saw you and Sá:k_i’s girlfriend in town.’ (my collaborator’s judgments)

- **Test 3: Demonstrative-headed DPs.** Suggests subject *pros* can corefer with R-expression possessors inside demonstrative-headed objects.
Problem: The judgments for these constructions are not clear cut...

(15) a. *Wa’e’nikhon’ ne thi:ken Arisawe ako’whahsa’.*
*pro*_{i/j} wa’-ie-’nikhon-’ ne thiken Arisawe; ako-’whahs-a’*
FACT-FIA-sew-PUNC NE that Arisawe FIP-skirt-NSF
‘She*_{i/j} sewed that skirt of Arisawe_i’s.’ (✗ coreference)

b. *Wahará:ko’ ne thi:ken Wishe raotó:ken.*
pro_i wa’-ha-r-a-kw-’ ne thiken Wishe; rao-atoken
FACT-MSGA-put.in-JR-REV-PUNC NE that Wishe MSGP-axe
‘He_i picked that axe of Wishe_i’s.’ (✓ coreference)